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College Hardships

With the economy at a low point again, a number of barriers can face independent college students, which can prevent them from becoming successful in obtaining a college degree. Unlike traditional students, who attend a college or a university on scholarship programs, or students whose parents can foot the total cost of tuition, these students are challenged with economic hardships. Untraditional students can face such obstacles as having to work while enrolled in college, lacking transportation to their courses, or balancing efforts to raise a family with college demands.

First, students working at a full-time job while attending college face severe time restrictions. When students have full-time jobs, they usually have to work no less than 40 hours a week. If a student is working and attending college full-time, class time generally equals no less than 12 hours a week. The rule of thumb for success at school is that for every hour of college classes taken, 3–4 hours of homework or study time is required per week. Don't let 12 hours of college classes sound easy: 40 hours of work a week, 12 hours of classes a week, and 24–36 hours of study time or homework a week are an extraordinary challenge. This schedule leaves little time for family or leisure. Forget about a morning jog around campus or an hour with a favorite television program! Time management, therefore, is a major problem many college students face.

Second, inconvenient transportation options form a barrier many students may encounter, and that causes difficulty commuting to school. If students do not live along a bus line, have access to public transportation, or carpool with students who drive and attend the same institution, this problem will keep them from arriving at school on time, if at all on some days. Also, paying for the commute is a challenge for financially strapped students. In addition, many students may live far away and spend large amounts of time getting to class. One student in psych lecture travels two hours each way to reach a nine o'clock class twice a week. Two hours each way! So, transportation is a real problem for many college students today.

Last, a student who also is a parent may face other difficulties while trying to earn a degree. With the divorce rate soaring sky high, many students are single parents and have financial hardships. Parents who work full-time and attend college also may feel as if they are neglecting their children. Getting adequate child care is a gnawing problem. In some cases, where both parents are present and working, their children may not be eligible for child care. Often, two salaries added together exceed income guidelines, so agencies have to deny daycare services, which further compounds the problem of college attendance. One of the requirements reflected in the policies enforced by Departments of Health and Human Resources is that child care will be available only to individuals who have a low enough income to qualify. With no one to watch a toddler at home, forget about working toward a degree.

Fortunately, some colleges offer child care without federal or state restrictions, and the services are very helpful to those students with children. Therefore, obtaining a college degree becomes a very hard task for students who are trying to work and attend classes, commute back and forth to college, and raise a family. These factors make attending college difficult to some and impossible for others. When deciding to attend college, students need to take into account the various obstacles that may face them. College is something a person has to want passionately and has to work at very hard in order to succeed!